

ILLUMINATI

Great Men with Best Intentions

ILLUMINATI

FACTFILE

CURRENT MEMBERS

BLACK BOLT

Inhuman King with lethal voice.

DR. STRANGE

Master of the mystic arts.

IRON MAN

Genius engineer wearing powered armor.

MR. FANTASTIC

Genius scientist with elastic body.

NAMOR

Mutant Atlantean king.

PROFESSOR X

Powerful telepath.

BASE

New York City

FIRST APPEARANCE

New Avengers #7 (July 2005)

ALLIES/FOES

ALLIES Atlanteans, Avengers, Fantastic Four, X-Men, Inhumans.

FOES Cabal, Kree, Skrulls.

ISSUE #1

Iron Man gathers the leaders of the superpowered community in Wakanda to discuss forming an official organization for heroes. Instead, the Illuminati is born.

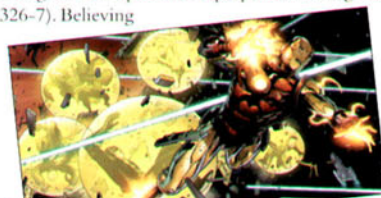


Iron Man's first attempt to band together the best minds on the planet failed due to a lack of trust among them.

CAPTURED BY SKRULLS

When the Illuminati traveled to the Skrull homeworld to deliver a warning, the Skrull ruler refused to heed them. Black Bolt destroyed his warship. Unfortunately, the Illuminati were captured as they tried to leave the system. After bringing the Illuminati back to the planet, the Skrulls separated them and nullified their powers. Then they analyzed their prisoners, learning much that they would later use to give their operatives superpowers during the Secret Invasion (see pp. 326-7). Believing

Iron Man to be helpless without his armor, they were careless, and Stark found the opportunity to break loose and to free the others.



While Iron Man was the only one of the Illuminati able to cope with being tossed into outer space, the Skrulls thought very little of him and his armor.

THE INFINITY GAUNTLET

Two events that nearly destroyed everyone in the universe involved the Infinity Gauntlet, a glove that holds the six Infinity Gems, assembling them into an artifact that grants the wearer limitless power. Mr. Fantastic began collecting the gems and turned to the Illuminati to help him. Namor, Professor X, and Dr. Strange searched for the Mind Gem, while Black Bolt, Mr. Fantastic, and Iron Man went after the Reality Gem. Once the Gauntlet was complete, the Watcher showed up to see what would happen and scolded them for meddling with such power. Mr. Fantastic chose to try to use the Gauntlet to destroy itself. When that failed, he removed the gems from the Gauntlet and gave one to each member of the Illuminati to safeguard in secret.

GROUP LISTING

1 Iron Man 2 Black Bolt
3 Dr. Strange 4 Mr. Fantastic
5 Namor 6 Professor X.

OTHER ADVENTURES

Later, the Illuminati approached the BEYONDER directly during the second Secret Wars. Professor X convinced the Beyonder that he had once been an Inhuman who'd been a mutant even before being exposed to the Terrigen Mists. Because of this, Black Bolt—who was therefore the Beyonder's king—could command him to leave, and did. After that, when MARVEL BOY (Noh-Varr) was imprisoned on Earth, the Illuminati visited him in his cell. They showed him that the Kree created the Inhumans to protect the Earth, not conquer it, and they encouraged him to follow the example set by

CAPTAIN MAR-VELL.



Deeming the Hulk too dangerous to remain on Earth, the Illuminati shot him into space.

EXILING THE HULK

The Illuminati arranged for a Life Model Decoy (android) version of Nick Fury to send the Hulk on a mission into space to disable a dangerous satellite. Once he entered the satellite, it turned into a starcraft and rocketed away, programmed to release the Hulk on an idyllic but unpopulated planet. Unfortunately, the ship wound up on the war-torn planet Sakaar instead. Namor refused to have any part of this mission, and Professor X was too busy to take part in it, but the other four managed it on their own. The Hulk later returned to exact his revenge during World War Hulk (see pp. 152-5).



THE CABAL

After killing the Skrull Queen VERANKE during the Secret Invasion, Norman Osborn (GREEN GOBLIN) came into power as the head of SHIELD—and then its replacement, HAMMER. To consolidate his position as the man in charge of all superhuman activity in the US, Osborn formed a secret organization of his own, called the Cabal. This included Dr. Doom, Emma Frost, the Hood, Loki, Namor, and himself. While the six ostensibly worked together, behind the scenes they began scheming against each other.

ESSENTIAL STORYLINES

- **New Avengers #7-10** The Illuminati makes its first appearance to discuss the problem of the Sentry.
- **New Avengers: Illuminati #1-5** The Illuminati gather for a series of secret adventures, starting with the aftermath of the Kree-Skrull War.
- **World War Hulk #1-5** The Hulk comes back from outer space to have his revenge on the members of the Illuminati who kicked him off Earth.

WAR AND INVASION

The Civil War (see pp. 84-5) shattered the Illuminati. Mr. Fantastic and Iron Man supported backing the Superhuman Registration Act, but Dr. Strange and Black Bolt strongly disagreed. Namor abstained, considering it no problem of Atlantis, and Professor X was not available to comment at the time. No one was willing to change his mind, so the Illuminati ended. Despite this, when Iron Man discovered an impending Secret Invasion (see pp. 326-7) by the Skrulls he called the Illuminati together again. The others discovered that Black Bolt had been replaced by an undetectable Skrull, and they barely defeated him. Afterward, they hoped to work together again but soon realized they could not trust each other any longer. **MF**



The lowest moment for the Illuminati came when the Superhuman Registration Act pitted them directly against each other. At the end of the Civil War that resulted from this, Iron Man felt forced to battle against his long-time friend and fellow Avenger Captain America.

